

PROMISING RETURN PRACTICES

POST-RETURN AFGHANISTAN

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Name of practice	Reintegration programs	
Dates	2023 - present	
Target group	Returnees	
Geographic Scope	Country	Afghanistan
	Regions	Asia
	Sub Region	South Asia
Actor	Ministry of Refugee and Reintegration High Commission on Returnees	
Return Stages	Post-Return	
Challenge addressed	Governance, Cooperation, and Coordination Reintegration Sustainability Institutional Capacity and Resources	
Principles referred (implicit or explicit)	Accountability Human-rights-based approach	

SUMMARY

As of 2025, the current political authority has framed return as a national priority, establishing a High Commission on Returnees within the Ministry of Refugees and Returnees (MoRR), which operates under cabinet-level oversight.

Operations are concentrated at key border points, such as Torkham, Jalalabad province bordering Pakistan, Spin Boldak, Kandahar province bordering Pakistan, Islam Qala, Herat province bordering Iran, linked to reception camps like Anzargi and Omari temporary settlement camps. The High Commission follows a structured workflow: people are first registered and screened at the “zero point,” then provided with immediate relief and basic protection, transported onward to camps or destination provinces, given temporary shelter and essential services, assessed and placed in education, supported with targeted cash assistance, and, where applicable, allocated land on a per-household member basis .

At each stage, international and non-state national aid organisations, particularly the UN agencies, play a critical role. For example, UNHCR leads on registration, emergency shelter, and cash or in-kind assistance; IOM focuses on safe transit, immediate relief, and support to vulnerable groups; and organisations such as the Norwegian Refugee Council (NRC), along with other UN agencies, INGOs and local NGOs, provide counselling, legal aid, and socio-economic support. Together, these actors deliver life-saving emergency assistance both at the border “zero points” and in destination provinces, helping returnees meet their basic needs and begin the process of reintegration.

BENEFITS/IMPACTS AND SHORTCOMINGS

Although the High Commission and the Ministry of Refugees and Repatriation (MoRR) have established legal and policy frameworks for return and reintegration, significant implementation gaps persist. Many rights and protection standards remain unrealised, and the dissolution of MoRR’s Directorate of Gender Affairs has further reduced the government’s ability to address gender-specific risks and vulnerabilities.

MoRR and the High Commission face major capacity constraints, and the effectiveness of new structures, particularly the High Commission and its twelve IEA-era sub-committees, remains uncertain and under-documented. This lack of clarity undermines coherent, nationwide coordination among state bodies responsible for return and reintegration.

Most assistance delivered under High Commission coordination remains short-term emergency support rather than sustainable, long-term economic or social programmes. Consequently, many returnees remain unemployed, financially precarious, and dependent on informal coping mechanisms instead of durable, state-led solutions.

Humanitarian access challenges further constrain the response. Non-state organisations and UN agencies face significant obstacles in delivering emergency assistance due to weak coordination with state institutions and restrictive policies, especially those limiting women's right to work. These restrictions prevent female humanitarian staff from reaching women and children, disrupting life-saving programmes at border points and in destination communities, and leave the most vulnerable returnees with only partial or no access to essential services.

Finally, the provision of adequate resources, training, and technical support to address and oversee the return and reintegration processes appears difficult due to the legal and policy deadlock created by the non-recognition of the Taliban government by the international community, including the United Nations.

KEY LESSONS

Coordination, Collaboration, and Burden-Sharing. The Afghan experience shows that large-scale and unpredictable return flows, coupled with limited institutional and financial capacity, cannot be managed by the government alone. The lack of effective joint planning and coordination between Afghan authorities and international agencies highlights the need for genuine hybrid approaches in which responsibility for protection and reintegration is shared.

Returnee-Inclusive Interventions. Returnees in Afghanistan have largely remained excluded from policy processes and decision-making bodies. This underscores the importance of developing returnee-led frameworks that ensure reintegration policies are tailored to their needs, experiences, and priorities, and that returnees have a meaningful voice in shaping the support they receive.

RECOMMENDATIONS

Strengthen institutional and operational capacity. Authorities responsible for return and reintegration should reinforce their institutional, managerial and financial capacity at both national and sub-national levels to effectively coordinate large-scale return flows. This includes establishing clear roles and responsibilities, improving inter-agency coordination with UN bodies and NGOs, and guaranteeing humanitarian access in line with humanitarian principles. In Afghanistan, this requires targeted support to MoRR, the High Commission and provincial structures, including joint coordination platforms and guaranteed access for humanitarian actors, including women aid workers.

Invest in sustainable, returnee-inclusive reintegration packages. Move beyond short-term emergency assistance by scaling up tailored reintegration support that combines vocational training, business start-up assistance, and employment creation, particularly for youth and women. These programmes should guarantee access to basic services, including healthcare, education, and adequate housing, and be designed in consultation with returnees and host communities, not just for them.

Establish evidence-based, coordinated regional policy frameworks. States experiencing large-scale return flows should develop regional mechanisms to collect reliable data, support policy dialogue, and guide sustainable, rights-based reintegration frameworks and programmes. Engagement of governments, international agencies, and civil society is required to promote policies that are coordinated, evidence-informed, and responsive to the needs of both returnees and host communities. In Afghanistan, the establishment of a Return and Reintegration Research and Policy Centre could bring together state and non-state institutions, UN agencies, the EU, and key host countries (such as Türkiye, Pakistan and Iran) with the aim of generating data, facilitating dialogue, and designing adequate frameworks.

REFERENCES

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